

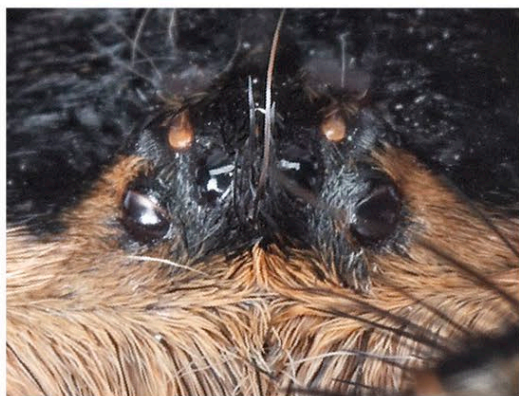
MEXICAN RED-KNEED TARANTULA

Brachypelma smithi

With its stout, furry body, the Mexican red-kneed tarantula might seem more mammal-like than spider-like. The female can live up to 30 years, which is unusual for an invertebrate, but the life span of the male is only up to six years. *Brachypelma smithi* is one of a group of spiders that gets the nickname of bird-eater because of their size, and although most of their diet consists of fellow arthropods, they can and do take down small mammals and reptiles when the opportunity arises. In its native Mexico this species lives in burrows in earth banks, where it is safe to moult and lay eggs, and from which it ambushes its prey. Habitat destruction is now a threat, and, as the species makes a popular pet, it is routinely bred in captivity.

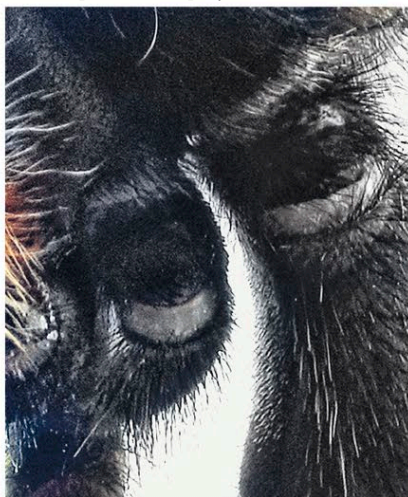


SIZE Body length 5–7.5 cm (2–3 in)
HABITAT Tropical deciduous forests
DISTRIBUTION Mexico
DIET Mostly insects



< EYES

Like most spiders, the tarantula has eight simple eyes arranged at the front of the head. Even so, it has poor vision, and relies more on touch than sight to sense its surroundings and the presence of prey.



legs are covered in specialized hairs sensitive to air movements and touch

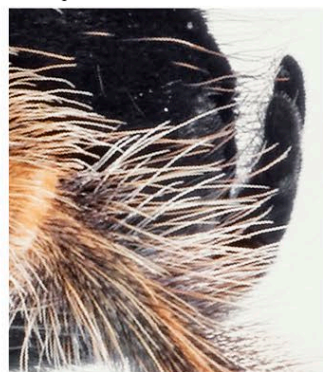
padded foot

< JOINTS

Like all arthropods, tarantulas have jointed legs. Each leg consists of seven tubular sections of exoskeleton that connect via flexible joints. Muscles run through these joints to move the sections.

< FOOT

At the tip of each foot are two claws used for grip as the tarantula moves. As in other hunting spiders, there are also pads of tiny hairs for extra purchase on smooth surfaces.



< SPINNERETS

Glands in the abdomen produce silk in liquid form. Using its hind legs, the tarantula pulls the silk from tubes called spinnerets. The silk solidifies into threads used to make egg sacs and line the spider's burrow.

^ VENOMOUS FANGS

Tarantula fangs hinge forward when attacking prey — unlike most other spiders, whose fangs are angled towards each other. Both fangs inject venom from muscular sacs within the head to paralyse the victim.

